

WORKFORCE WELL-BEING, EQUITY AND TRANSFORMATION

DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICE AND ADMINISTRATION

03 - 05 MARCH 2026



the dpsa

Department:
Public Service and Administration
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

**“Growing South Africa together for a
capable and ethical Public Service”**



BACKGROUND

- The Public Sector Coordinating Bargaining Council (PSCBC) is in the process of convening its Strategic Planning Session in March 2026 as well as the Public Sector Summit during the 2026/2027 FY.
- The 2022 Public Sector Summit was held in Johannesburg over the period 28-31 March 2022 under the theme *“Strengthening and defending centralized collective bargaining to advance economic development, social justice, a capable and developmental state, labour peace and the democratization of the workspace”*
- The 2010 Public Sector Summit was held in Durban from 11 to 13 March 2010 under the theme *“Positioning the Public Service for a Developmental State through Effective Service Delivery”* at Inkosi Albert Luthuli Convention Centre.

PURPOSE

This presentation outlines the progress made by government in giving effect to the summit outcomes, with specific reference to policy reforms, employment equity targets, institutional mechanisms, and monitoring frameworks.

Thematic area # 4
Workforce Well-Being, Equity and Transformation

COORDINATION, IMPLEMENTATION AND MONITORING

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- The PSCBC is vested with the central coordination role for the various thematic/workstream areas outlined in the 2022 Summit Declaration.
- Pursuant to that responsibility, the employer caucus led by the DPSA is convened in a pre-strategic planning session to take stock of the work achieved to-date and consider plans going forward.

POLICY AND LEGISLATIVE INTERVENTIONS

- **The Constitutional Anchor (Sec 9 & 195)**

The DPSA executes the Constitutional Mandate for a "broadly representative" public service. This move transitions from Formal Equality (the law) to Substantive Equality (active redress for Women, Youth, and PWDs).

- **Employment Equity (EE) & SMS Targets**

Enforcing the Employment Equity Amendment Act. The DPSA has institutionalised the 50% Women in Senior Management Service (SMS) target and is driving toward the 7% PWD employment target by 2030.

- **ILO Convention 190 (C190) Integration**

The DPSA led the translation of ILO C190 into the 2024 Public Service Harassment Guide. This provides the legal shield against victimisation, bullying, and gender-based violence (GBV) in the "world of work."

- **The "Care Economy" Mandate (Sec 28)**

Guided by the "Best Interests of the Child," the DPSA utilizes PSCBC Resolutions to exceed BCEA minimums—positioning the State as an Exemplary Employer through paid maternity and proposed childcare support.

- **Accountability Mechanism**

Transformation is no longer "optional." The DPSA integrates these mandates directly into Heads of Department (HOD) Performance Agreements, ensuring consequence management for non-compliance with equity targets.

- **The 2024 DPSA Harassment Guide**

- The DPSA recently updated the Guide on the Prevention and Elimination of Harassment in the Public Service, aligning it with ILO Convention 190. This guide provides a uniform, zero-tolerance protocol for all 1.3 million public servants.
- Confidential Reporting: Shifted from traditional grievance structures to gender-sensitive reporting mechanisms, ensuring that victims of sexual harassment or bullying can report without fear of career-ending victimisation.

- **Gender-Responsive Workplace Culture**

- Lactation & Care Support: Through the DPSA Employee Health and Wellness Strategic Framework, the department has institutionalised the requirement for breastfeeding-friendly workspaces, recognising the woman's role as primary caregiver.
- Domestic Violence Spillover: For the first time, DPSA policy formally recognises domestic violence as a workplace issue, allowing for discretionary leave and workplace adjustments for survivors—a major gain in the fight against GBVF.

- **Monitoring and Accountability**

- HOD Performance Agreements: The DPSA has integrated Employment Equity targets directly into the performance contracts of Heads of Department, ensuring that the 50% representation of women in SMS (Senior Management Service) is not just a goal, but a KPI.

TABULATED GAINS IN LINE WITH LEGISLATIVE MANDATE

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Focus Area	Key Strategic "Gain"	Impact in the Public Service
Women in Leadership	45.67% Female Representation in Senior Management (SMS).	Moving rapidly toward the DPSA 50% Cabinet target through the 8-Principle Action Plan.
Disability Inclusion	New 3% Minimum Target for 2024/25.	Cabinet approved a 1% annual target to reach the 7% Employment Equity target by 2030.
Youth Economic Participation	R250 Million Additional Funding for the National Youth Service.	Continuation of the Presidential Youth Employment Initiative (PYEI) to scale graduate placements and internships.
Workplace Safety	2024 DPSA Harassment Guide.	Fully aligns the Public Service with ILO Convention 190, legally defining and penalising bullying and digital victimisation.
Reproductive Rights	EE Targets in HOD Contracts.	Transformation is a KPA for Accounting Officers with the DPSA and DWYPD monitoring departmental compliance annually.

PROTECTION AGAINST VICTIMISATION & HARASSMENT

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- **ILO Convention 190 (C190) Implementation:**

The DPSA has institutionalized ILO C190 into the Public Service Harassment Guide (2024). This moves beyond physical safety to protecting the psychological integrity of Women, Youth, and PWDs.

- **Defining the "World of Work"**

Protections are no longer limited to the office. DPSA policy now covers victimization occurring during commutes, field work, work-related travel, and digital platforms (WhatsApp/Email), specifically targeting "cyber-bullying" of young professionals.

- **Eradicating Gender-Based Violence (GBVF)**

In line with the National Strategic Plan on GBVF, the DPSA has formalized Section 173 Disciplinary Procedures to ensure sexual harassment cases are handled with "victim-centric" sensitivity, preventing secondary victimization by the employer.

- **Consequence Management**

Victimization is now classified as Gross Misconduct. The DPSA monitors departmental Labour Relations Reports to ensure that perpetrators are held accountable, breaking the culture of silence in the workplace.

- **Whistleblower & Witness Protection**

Strengthening the Protected Disclosures Act within the public service. The DPSA mandates that no employee—particularly vulnerable Youth or PWDs—shall face "occupational detriment" for reporting discrimination or corruption.

- The Chief Directorate: Gender, Youth and Disability Mainstreaming in the DPSA was established in 2023 to:
 - Coordinate transversal implementation of summit outcomes.
 - Develop guidelines for gender-responsive and disability-inclusive planning and budgeting.
 - Conduct readiness assessments across national and provincial departments.
- Disability Rights Branch (Department of Women, Youth and Persons with Disabilities)
 - Leads the Interdepartmental Task Team on Disability Inclusion.
 - Developed the National Disability Rights Charter and monitoring scorecard.
- Youth empowerment initiatives Desks in National Departments
 - Departments have partnered with various SETA, through the Department of Higher Education.
- Education to provide them with workplace experience.
 - There are youth programmes, recruitment, and skills development.

- **Women in Leadership Programme**

- Mentorship and leadership pipeline programme targeting women at middle management level facilitated by the Nationals School of Government
- PSCBC Women negotiators training,

- **Youth Empowerment Programme**

- Youth Activation Programme are placed in public service through internships (2024/25).

- **Disability Inclusion Accelerator Plan**

- Annual recruitment targets set for each department.

Implementing these progressive policies within the public service involves navigating deep-rooted structural, financial, and cultural obstacles.

1. Challenges to the Basic Childcare Policy

- **Infrastructure & Regulatory Barriers:** Many potential sites for workplace ECD centres face complex municipal zoning, land use, and health and safety requirements that can take years to resolve.
- **Funding Constraints:** Existing state subsidies for ECD are often insufficient to cover operational costs, and there is a significant public financing gap to meet national infrastructure and training targets.

2. Obstacles to the 7% Disability Target

- **Non-Disclosure:** A significant barrier is the reluctance of employees to disclose disabilities due to stigma or fear of discrimination, which prevents them from receiving necessary reasonable accommodations.
- **Infrastructural & Managerial Gaps:** Many government buildings remain physically inaccessible, and some managers still perceive employees with disabilities as a "burden" or a "social responsibility" rather than a productive talent pool.
- **Attitudinal Barriers:** Deep-seated stereotypes among "abled" staff and a lack of awareness about invisible disabilities (like autism or mental health) persist in many departments.

3. Barriers to Eradicating Victimisation & Harassment

- **Power Imbalances:** Victims often do not report harassment because the harasser is in a powerful position, leading to fears of further isolation, ridicule, or career-ending retaliation.
- **Institutional "Silos":** Employment Equity (EE) plans are often developed by coordinators without the involvement of other line programmes, leading to a lack of a common understanding of "mainstreaming" across departments.
- **Complexity of the "World of Work":** Applying the 2024 DPSA Harassment Guide beyond physical office premises to digital spaces and work-related travel requires extensive and ongoing training for all staff.

4. Youth Empowerment Bottlenecks

- **Structural Unemployment:** High youth unemployment is rooted in deep structural problems, including a mismatch between skills and available job opportunities in the public sector.
- **Lack of Integrated Career Pathways:** There is often a "fragmented approach" where youth, especially those with disabilities, struggle to transition from classrooms to meaningful workplaces due to a lack of interconnected support systems.

- **Implementation of the Basic Childcare Framework**

Formalize and enforce the intervention that government will champion towards a universal childcare support, including workplace ECD facilities and lactation rooms.

- **Enforce the 7% Disability Target**

Direct all Accounting Officers to align their Annual Performance Plans (APPs) with the Cabinet-approved 7% PWD target, ensuring that "Reasonable Accommodation" budgets are ring-fenced and non-negotiable.

- **Zero-Tolerance for Victimization**

Roll out the 2024 DPSA Harassment Guide training across all provinces to ensure that ILO Convention 190 standards are lived in every government office, protecting our youth and women from institutional bullying.

- **Strengthen Consequence Management**

Institutionalize the use of Transformation Scorecards in HOD Performance Agreements. Non-compliance with gender, youth, and disability targets must carry direct administrative and performance-related consequences.

- **Scale the Youth Employment Initiative**

Expand the Presidential Youth Employment Intervention (PYEI) within the public service, focusing on priority placements for young women and youth with disabilities in high-growth technical sectors.



THANK YOU



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